# Understanding chronic conditions

A short introduction

## What is a chronic condition?

A chronic condition is a health problem that lasts a long time and may need ongoing care. Many can be managed rather than cured. Examples include diabetes, arthritis, fibromyalgia and asthma.

## Every person is different

Some symptoms are visible; others are not. Depending on the condition, someone may experience pain, tiredness or difficulty concentrating. Symptoms can change, so a task that is manageable one day may be harder another day.

## Support is more than medicine

Care may include medicines, practical equipment, therapy or help with everyday tasks. A GP, nurse, pharmacist or specialist may be involved. Care and activity advice should suit the person and their particular condition.

## Understanding helps

Believe people when they describe their difficulties. Ask what would help, allow flexibility and respect their choices. Looking well does not mean someone feels well. A long-term condition does not define the whole person.

## When to speak to someone

Ask your GP or care team about new, changing or worrying symptoms. Do not assume every new symptom is part of an existing condition. Seek urgent help for an emergency.

For general information only. Hadamley Information Services provides independently compiled information from publicly available sources. This content is not medical advice and should not be used to diagnose or treat a condition or replace advice from a qualified healthcare professional. Speak to your healthcare team about symptoms, treatment or changes to your health.

**Sources and further reading (clickable in the PDF):**

NHS: long-term conditions
NHS: health conditions
NHS: tiredness and fatigue

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